

Building a Cloud Strategy to Boost Digital Innovation

This article discusses why it is necessary to build an organisational cloud strategy and how to go about doing that.

The role of cloud as an IT and business tool is now more than a decade old. Globally, IT departments are migrating their business applications from on-premises to public cloud platforms at a continuous pace. Gartner, a global market research player, expects this rate to pick up as legacy systems reach their end-of-life support and migration projects get underway.

However, on the flip side, many enterprise chief information officers (CIOs) have still to announce and formulate a well-defined cloud strategy for their internal IT and business end users. If well thought out and articulated, a cloud strategy can become a blueprint for the roll-out of revamped and forward-looking digital processes, job roles and change in organisational structures.

Here is a checklist of how CIOs can build their cloud strategies.

List expected business outcomes

The starting point for building any cloud strategy is to get a complete picture of the desired business outcomes over short and medium terms. At this stage, it is important to focus on benefits from the point of view of business end users rather than IT end users. A successful cloud strategy sets up a culture of self-service across the organisation, adding in new business end users into the organisation's connected network, thereby fostering a culture of self-driven innovation.



Are cloud and digital strategies aligned?

A successful cloud strategy cannot be developed without aligning it with the digital innovation strategy of the organisation. The organisation's cloud platform enables the rest of the digital experience and digital work processes to be built upon it. Lack of alignment between the two strategies in terms of requirements of scalability, application workloads, reliability and geographic responsiveness will lead to failure of the digital innovation strategy and lack of any business returns from the cloud rollout strategy.

Is business more agile than IT?

Who is driving innovation in the organisation? If it is the business that

is moving faster than IT, then key business decision makers need to be involved during the formulation of the organisational cloud strategy. By bringing business decision makers into the development of the cloud strategy at an early stage, it is more likely that investments required for the cloud rollout can be justified against investments required for digital business innovation.

Plan out critical and supporting workloads

A cloud strategy is not meant to be an IT showcase of sorts. The prime purpose is business innovation, business agility and significant improvement in IT operations and cost. A cloud strategy